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Homeowners feel pain of property tax hike

Some in Boston on fixed incomes fear they're being pushed out

By Andrew Brinker
GLOBE STAFF

Almost 50 years ago, Sherry Peterson and her now ex-husband put their funds together to buy an old three-family building in Mattapan to be their home.

It was a charming place, and big, in a neighborhood that some were fleeing in droves in the era of busing and white flight, leaving a glut of homes behind. The couple paid less

than \$20,000.

All these years later, Peterson is still living in that home, which now needs constant repairs. She lives downstairs, and rents the second-floor unit to her daughter, her son-in-law, and their three children. Maybe the biggest change since she moved in in the late 1970s is that the house's value has skyrocketed, to roughly \$800,000, 40 times more than what Peterson paid for it.

On paper, that means she owns a valuable asset. But Peterson doesn't see that value in her day-to-day expenses. Instead, the cost of owning her house, and chiefly the property tax she pays each year, has shot up — to \$1,200 in the last quarter. It's making it harder for Peterson to afford maintenance, and even to stay in the neighborhood.

"I spent my life working to be able to afford to retire in this house,"

said Peterson, who is also an activist with the Massachusetts Senior Action Council. "Now all of my money is going to insurance and taxes, and here comes the city saying they want more of my money for taxes. How can people be expected to afford living here?"

Now Peterson has more bad news. Her tax bill is about to jump even higher.

Mayor Michelle Wu's proposal to shield homeowners from the brunt

PROPERTY TAXES, Page A7

Biden commutes sentences of 1,500

Most granted by a president in a day; 39 are pardoned

By Zolan Kanno-Youngs
NEW YORK TIMES

WASHINGTON — President Biden said Thursday that he is commuting the sentences of nearly 1,500 people and pardoning 39 people convicted of nonviolent crimes in a sweeping act of clemency during his final weeks in office.

The commutations — the largest number by a president in a single day, the White House said — affect those who had been released from prison and placed in home confinement during the coronavirus pandemic. The pardons went to people convicted of nonviolent crimes, including drug offenses.

"America was built on the promise of possibility and second chances," Biden said in a statement. He said the clemency represented his commitment to "help reunite families, strengthen communities and reintegrate individuals back into society."

A pardon wipes out a conviction, while a commutation leaves the guilty verdict intact but reduces some or all of the punishment.

Biden's action was one of the biggest grants of clemency in modern American history. President Jimmy Carter, on his first full day in office in 1977, issued a pardon that affected more people, for men who evaded the Vietnam War draft. But that was

► **Maine man convicted decades ago gets a pardon. B1.**

BIDEN, Page A6

Flooded tunnel could be sign of things to come

Rain events are getting increasingly potent, leading to a clogged drain this time

By Shannon Larson and Travis Andersen
GLOBE STAFF

Drivers encountered a startling scene in the Ted Williams Tunnel Wednesday night after a deluge of heavy rain battered the region: a roadway submerged by several feet of water because of a clogged drain.

The wheel-deep waters lapped like ocean waves against motorists' vehicles as they carefully attempted to navigate their way through the flooding. Dramatic video footage of the partially submerged tunnel and cars moving at a slow crawl quickly circulated online.

"I have never seen [a] flood in the tunnel, it was my first time," said Maria Barajas, 32, of Boston, who was traveling in an Uber with her fiancé and a friend from the Seaport to the Liberty Hotel.

When they reached the swamped tunnel, their driver slowed the car to make sure it wouldn't stall out. They were part of a line of vehicles moving in single file on the left side of the roadway.

While the severe flooding was deemed a "pretty

TUNNEL, Page A7



MIKAEL ULLÉN

In Stockholm, a new sorting facility separates food scraps and plastics from waste.



Zero Waste Stockholm

Members of the nonprofit have an approach to reducing waste that goes far beyond what most cities are doing. And they set the highest bar for themselves. **A10.**

WASTE, Page A10

AN EXAMPLE FOR MASS. TO REUSE

Sweden offers a number of strategies to reduce municipal waste. But ultimately it comes down to mindset.

By Ivy Scott
GLOBE STAFF

STOCKHOLM
On a chilly autumn morning in the Norra Djurgården district, a woman holding a small garbage bag hustled out of her apartment toward a trio of nondescript metal bins next to her building, each with a different colored door: blue for newspapers, yellow for plastic, and gray for other trash.

Tapping an ID card on the gray bin to unlock it, she pulled the door open and dropped the garbage bag inside the nearly full bin. While the woman went on with her day, her trash began a journey of

its own: first sucked into a network of vacuum-propelled underground tubes, then funneled several hundred meters to a trash compressor, then transported via truck to a state-of-the-art sorting facility where cutting-edge technology separates food waste and plastics from the garbage.

In Sweden, a world leader in minimizing municipal waste, the goal is for every possible scrap to be recycled, composted, or turned to biogas.

The need for action is urgent. Massachusetts now exports more than a third of its trash out of state, while its six overburdened landfills are expected to fill by 2030. All those landfills release

WASTE, Page A10

Donald Trump set out his agenda for his first day in office, saying he'll pardon Jan. 6 participants and begin deportations of some immigrants. **A2.**

Attorney General Andrea J. Campbell is leaving Boston, the city she once campaigned to lead, buying a house on the state's South Coast. **B1.**

Icing on the lake

Friday: Sunny but cold. High 32-37. Low 22-27.
Saturday: More of the same. High 34-39. Low 21-26.
Sunrise: 7:05 Sunset: 4:12
Weather and Comics, G8-9. Obituaries, C9.



'I didn't come here to leave'

Bill Belichick explained why he took the UNC job and indicated he has no plans to jump back to the NFL. **C1.**

With all eyes on him, a high flying bird

A peacock that can't be caught is the center of attention in Essex

By Billy Baker
GLOBE STAFF

ESSEX — The peacock stood on a roof on Western Avenue, staring down at Amy Reilly. They've been through this drill many times.

"Hey, handsome, I'm back," she said to the bird, which was giving her the side-eye. "You want to come with me?"

The bird did not, and with a flippancy flash of flamboyant feathers, walked to the other side of the roof and out of sight.

Reilly is the animal control officer in Essex and an expert on failing to catch this peacock. Their standoff has been going on since late summer, when the mystery peacock appeared and quickly established itself as a local celebrity in this coastal village on the North Shore. Some people call him "Liberace"; others prefer "The Disco Chicken."

Social media has been clogged with photos of the bird — which set up shop along a busy road with two popular restaurants on one side of the street and a small neighborhood on the other — as well as calls that someone needs to do *something* before the bird gets killed by a car or a coyote.

PEACOCK, Page A10



CRAIG F. WALKER/GLOBE STAFF

The peacock appeared in the late summer, and quickly established itself as a local celebrity.

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